

subscribe to a dynamic feed of news items containing that keyword. This allows you to search for information based on your topic of interest.

Given the wealth of offerings and features, this is one of the best RSS readers available today. The offline mode is quite a lifesaver, and online synchronisation with Newsgator is a big plus.

Rating: ★★★★★

FeedReader 3

<http://www.feedreader.com/>

Price: Free.

Size: 5.2 MB

Supporting a simple, clean UI, FeedReader 3 is a lightweight app that can manage a large number of feeds and run queries on them. If you're an information junkie, FeedReader will meet your needs.

FeedReader has many solutions to manipulate the feeds and the information that you receive — *Smart Feeds* — which lets you search for a keyword or topic within your feed, *Search Feed*: which lets you subscribe to a keyword on del.icio.us, Flickr Photo, Google News, Technocrati, Youtube, Ebay, Google Blog, MSN search, and Yahoo News.

FeedReader can also download enclosures attached to the feeds, including podcasts, which are saved to a local folder. You can add your own tags to the articles while saving them locally. The application can be minimised to the tray, and a neat little alert slider keeps you informed whenever a feed

has an update. You can set the update frequency of a feed, either in minutes or use its own special feed-reader sensitive algorithm (Intelliupdate), which won't poll for a new item and spam the feed.

It's a lightweight and user-friendly app, but lack of synchronisation features with the likes of Bloglines, Google Reader or Newsgator or any such service is a sore spot — other apps can do what Feed Reader 3 can and more (sync podcasts with iTunes, Craigslist and eBay searches), and they're free too.

Rating: ★★★★★

Snarfer

<http://www.snarware.com/snarfer.htm>

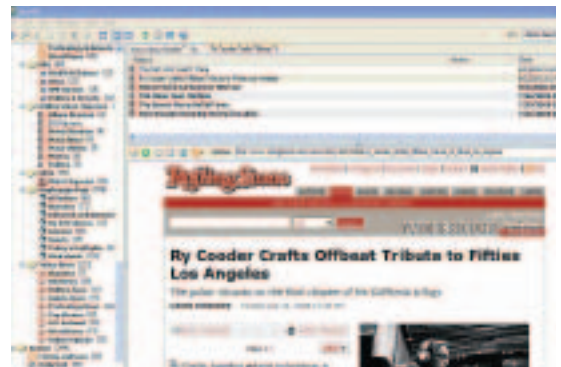
Price: Free

Size: 396 KB

One of the most popular desktop-client-based RSS readers — Snarfer can do a lot more than just help you read and manage RSS feeds. At first, this tiny app looks like it has a very basic serving — but once you dig in, you realise this is the one of most usable and enduring apps around.

It has a simple three pane user interface, with your feeds listed in folders on the left; in the centre, the Folder view sorts the news by subject, date, and source. The preview pane has an embedded browser which supports tabbed windows, and has a Web search toolbar that works with all the major RSS/Blog search engines.

You can get started by importing feeds from other readers — Snarfer supports the OPML standard, you can manually set refresh frequency for each feed, and drag and drop relevant stories into a save folder. Snarfer's development team brings out new version updates every 45 days; recent features include the ability to search on eBay or Craigslist — an excellent feature that works well with eBay India as well. Say you're planning to buy an 8GB iPod Nano, you



Snarfer has a simple three pane user interface, with your feeds listed in folders on the left

can add that as a new search, and enter the maximum and minimum price you are willing to pay for it. So instead of making searches on these web sites every day, you have a persistent search that let's you choose from the best of these deals as they happen.

New plug-ins for Snarfer make it more powerful — one helps you synchronise your feeds with your online Bloglines account, so that you have the best of both worlds -a powerful desktop application when you're using your PC, and an online counterpart that helps you access your feeds, bookmarks and searches on any other computer. There's a plug-in that can synchronise Snarfer with your Google Reader account, so your feeds can be accessed from a browser when you can't use Snarfer. We tried using both the plug-ins, and while the Bloglines plug-in worked like a charm, the Google Reader plug-in was unable to connect. Snarfer's flexibility in working with other online feed readers is one of its strongest plus points.

There's a plug-in that can make Snarfer monitor Stocks, another that can post to del.icio.us.

While Snarfer lacks some of the features present in FeedDemon and FeedReader (Support for podcasts, Offline Reading Mode), the ability to add new plug-ins, download new styles, and synchronise with Bloglines and Google Reader puts it squarely ahead of the pack. ■

Rating: ★★★★★



A newly downloaded style plug-in emulates the look and feel of the TechCrunch Web site